

| 1975 | SHOLAY

70 mm Spectacular

The first Indian film to adopt western techniques told a very Indian vendetta story

For one week after the release of *Sholay* on August 15, 1975, director Ramesh Sippy was a puzzled man. The trade papers had declared it a disaster, reviewers had been more than unkind—INDIA TODAY'S K.M. Amladi had called it a dead ember—and no one in the audience was either clapping or whistling at even the most powerful dialogues. And yet, shows were house full. "I saw that the audience was not reacting at all," says Sippy. What he failed to realise was that they were actually stunned into silence. A theatre owner in Worli, Mumbai, told him later that people weren't even buying popcorn in the interval because they were riveted to their seats. "It was only in the third week that people were repeating the dialogues and singing the songs," says Sippy. After six months of declaring it a dud, a trade paper finally woke up and said it had made a mistake. It even became the first Indian film to run in one theatre, Minerva in Mumbai, for five years. Developed from a four-line idea that Salim-Javed scripted in 1973, the story was first offered to Manmohan Desai. He ignored it and Sippy, the 26-year-old filmmaker who had made *Seeta aur Geeta*, took it on. Danny Denzongpa was set to play Gabbar Singh but pulled out due to date problems. Shatrughan Sinha was initially being considered for Jai but Sippy had his reservations. The film already had too many stars. Amitabh Bachchan was just starting out. It's a different thing that by the time the film released two years later, Bachchan had become box office gold thanks to *Zanjeer* and *Deewar*. A week before the Indian release the filmmakers decided to have a screening at the Odeon Marble Arch in London. The Indian high commissioner was also invited. "He was courteous but his tone was guarded," recalls Sippy. This was the time when Emergency was declared and the director didn't want to take chances. Acting on instinct, Sippy cancelled the show but reached the venue. As if on cue, officers zeroed in to arrest Sippy but backed off when they saw the show had been called off. "We later realised that the fine print said the sealed reel could only be opened in India," he says. It was because of this political

climate that *Sholay* didn't end the way Sippy wanted it to. The ending shot originally had Thakur kick Gabbar to death. But the Central Board of Film Certification didn't want a former police officer killing a dacoit for personal vendetta. They wanted the police to arrest Gabbar alive. The film's cult status gets reaffirmed when music channels continue to spoof the characters, including Dhanho; when advertisements still allude to Gabbar; and when 20-year-olds, who weren't even born in 1975, declare with as much force, "*Arre O Saambha, kitne aadmi the?*"

by Jhilmil Motihar



SIPPY EXPLAINING A SHOT TO AMJAD KHAN

THE MAIN EVENT

Emergency Declared

The day it happened no tanks rolled, no guns roared. There was not even an alert for the defence forces. It was business as usual at airports and railways stations, shops and offices, schools and colleges, homes and farms. Yet there was an undercurrent of tension in the city. Certain politicians had threatened to bring the whole nation to a standstill. Far fewer people were out on the otherwise busy roads of the India capital. Many stayed indoors, fearing violence. But there was none. It was a swift and silent constitutional step.

India Today, December 15, 1975



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